

Information, Communication & Society

ISSN: 1369-118X (Print) 1468-4462 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/rics20

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To cite this article: Taylor Annabell (27 May 2026): Calling out disclosures, protecting followers: the new governors of influencer culture on TikTok, Information, Communication & Society, DOI: 10.1080/1369118X.2026.2674878

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2026.2674878

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Published online: 27 May 2026.

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INFORMATION, COMMUNICATION & SOCIETY
https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2026.2674878

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Calling out disclosures, protecting followers: the new governors of influencer culture on TikTok

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ABSTRACT

Influencer marketing is a core monetisation practice within the creator economy, which contributes to the presence of commercial content on platforms. To ensure audiences are informed, influencers are legally and platform-mandated to disclose when their content is advertising. This article examines how disclosure, as a form of governance, is negotiated on TikTok by influencers who call out and are called out for undisclosed ads, as well as by users whom disclosure allegedly aims to protect. By analysing callout videos, their comments, and comments on the alleged undisclosed ads, the study explores interpretations of disclosure – relying on and extending beyond legal frameworks – and the strategic use of regulation by actors who position themselves as governors of influencer culture. I unpack how the absence of disclosure is constructed as (1) meaningful, aligning with the influencer's commercial goals, and leaving certain groups vulnerable because they are presumed to be unable to decode its commercial nature; and (2) unnecessary due to ambivalence toward governance through disclosure. Building on research about informal governance via calling out in influencer culture, I demonstrate how calling out is mobilised for engagement, contributes to the gendered policing of feminised digital labour, and oscillates between condemning harmful behaviour and causing harm.

ARTICLE HISTORY
Received 4 August 2025
Accepted 10 May 2026

KEYWORDS
Influencers; governance; advertising; disclosure; calling out

In October 2023, influencer agency founder and influencer Alice Bull (@aliceisgratified) called out influencer Grace Beverley on TikTok for not disclosing the online promotion of her clothing brand. In the video, Alice labelled Grace as the 'queen of illegal ad practices,' decoding Grace's content as undisclosed ads and showcasing her legal knowledge of the UK regulatory environment. Although Alice deleted the post within a day, the non-compliance claim sparked high engagement, which also turned into abuse directed towards Grace. Grace firmly refuted the accusation in a comment on Alice's post, a sarcastic update to her bio ('in case it isn't overtly clear, I made @wearetala') and an 8-minute video, referring to legal guidance and calling out, in turn, the online harassment

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Supplemental data for this article can be accessed online at https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2026.2674878.
This article has been corrected with minor changes. These changes do not impact the academic content of the article.

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and Alice's tendency to police the activities of female rather than male influencers. The ruling by the UK's Advertising Standards Authority (ASA) in May 2024, that in failing to identify her content as advertising, Grace had broken the rules speaks to the inherent messiness of influencer marketing where even influencers like Grace who obtain legal advice fall shy of their duties.

In this instance, Alice acts as governor of influencer culture, monitoring disclosure practices on behalf of audiences, who are presumed to need protection from influencers. The actions and narratives of Alice, Grace and other TikTok users are part of the circulation of drama within influencer culture (Lewis & Christin, 2022), which involves repositioning the legal obligation to disclose commercial content (Goanta & Ranchordás, 2020). Although specific legal systems are invoked by TikTok users who seek to enforce advertising rules like authorities and regulators, *calling out* undisclosed ads goes beyond compliance. At stake is what it means for influencers to responsibly share commercial content and who gets to assert what *good* governance looks like. Calling out, I argue, makes visible expectations of disclosure, which have implications for how influencers are perceived and indeed treated on platforms. As exemplified by the criticism of Grace, her work, and value by other TikTok users, audiences participate in the debate over accountability, where the undisclosed ad is treated as emblematic of issues with influencers. Critically, it becomes part of boundary work in the gendered creator economy (Duffy et al., 2022), leaning on harmful stereotypes about commercialism and superficiality, which is potentially amplified if, as Grace proposes, the calling out of professional shortcomings is *only* directed towards women.

This article contributes to our understanding of how the creator economy is governed across formal and informal regimes (Abidin et al., 2025; Annabell et al., 2025; Caplan & Gillespie, 2020; Goanta & Ranchordás, 2020; Joseph & Bishop, 2024; Meisner, 2023), by focusing on advertising disclosure, which received less attention in creator and influencer studies, and is traditionally addressed in legal and advertising literacy research. My focus on how both influencers and audiences approach disclosure as a governance mechanism offers necessary insight beyond measuring its effectiveness for protecting consumers. In part, I build on work examining how influencers utilise the legal framework of copyright within YouTube's system (Hallinan et al., 2024; Kaye & Gray, 2021), but I attend to two actors critical in the creator economy: influencers and audiences. By examining the practices and narratives of calling out across TikTok videos and comments, I show how influencers and audiences perceive ad disclosures as meaningful and irrelevant mechanisms of governance within the complexity of regulatory regimes across geographic contexts that are contested and collapsed within TikTok culture. In addition, I surface interpretations of legal frameworks and demonstrate how regulation is strategically wielded to establish legitimacy in the creator economy by specific influencers. In doing so, I conceptually and empirically advance work on calling out practices (Geusens et al., 2023; Lawson, 2021; Lee & Abidin, 2024; Lewis & Christin, 2022; Nakamura, 2015) through the specific case study of disclosure in influencer ads and more broadly, in thinking through the intersection of public accountability and shaming. Lack of disclosures becomes a way to discuss disliked aspects of influencer culture and generate engagement, whilst also grappling with the transparency and professional ethics of influencers. As such, this article offers a critical assessment of both disclosure as a form of governance from those subject to the rules and for whom protection is being

enacted, and the limits of calling out as an accountability practice because of the entanglement with logics of visibility, drama and monetisation on platforms.

Governing the creator economy

The creator economy refers to the ecosystem where influencers generate income through the monetisation of content creation. This bourgeoning industry is projected to be worth $480 billion by 2027 (Goldman Sachs, 2023), especially thanks to influencer marketing. Different actors attempt to manage and structure the actions of influencers through the exercise of authority, establishing rules, expectations, and obligations, implicitly and explicitly, formally and informally. This includes platforms that regulate influencers through their policies, interface designs, monetisation programmes, and monitoring and enforcement processes (Annabell et al., 2025; Caplan & Gillespie, 2020; Kopf, 2022). It also involves states and regulators through legal frameworks applicable to the activities of influencers, such as consumer and media law (Goanta & Ranchordás, 2020), along with brands and intermediaries like talent managers.

While these forms of institutional power intervene in the working lives of influencers, engender dependencies, and crystallise inequalities (see, for example, Glatt, 2024), influencers and their audiences also develop self-governance practices to push back. For example, YouTube creators debate moderation policies and practices (Hallinan et al., 2025), and the implementation of copyright law on the platform (Hallinan et al., 2024; Kaye & Gray, 2021). Hallinan et al. (2024) distinguish between horizontal callouts, where creators address other creators and invoke the shared value of community, and vertical callouts, where creators address platforms, appealing to fairness. As they demonstrate, efforts to enforce formal and informal rules in the creator economy through calling out are a form of governance.

Calling out and critiquing influencer behaviour

Calling out as 'discursive accountability practice' can be traced back to Black oral traditions (Clark, 2020, p. 89), in which, in the practice of Black women, there is 'a critique of systemic inequality rather than an attack against specific, individualistic transgressions' (Brock, 2020, p. 220). Work on calling out in the creator economy coalesces around the intersection of influencer behaviour with patriarchal structures, racism, and consumer capitalism. Rather than calling outs of brands (Lawson, 2021), most research addresses callouts amongst influencers (Geusens et al., 2023; Lewis & Christin, 2022) or audiences (Duffy et al., 2022; Lee & Abidin, 2024). The latter speaks to the volatility between influencers and audiences, in which Gurrieri et al. (2023) caution against underestimating the power and impact that the latter can hold.

For Clark (2020, p. 88), the mobilisation of 'useful anger by minoritised people and groups' has transformed into a social media 'strategy for networked framing of extant social problems.' As a result, demanding accountability through calling out has been co-opted and hollowed out in 'cancel culture.' This is partially evidenced by the emergence of callout as a content genre. Geusens et al. (2023) highlight how accountability is emphasised in callout videos, which can overshadow how jealousy and business interests often drive these acts. Calling out can be used to serve interests that go beyond

merely 'talking back' to dominant discourses and structures. This is because 'drama' attracts attention and can be monetised (Lewis & Christin, 2022), turning calling out into a means of engagement.

Nevertheless, influencer callouts draw on discourses that represent influencer culture and the broader digital environment. Influencers and their behaviour become a vehicle for creators and audiences to discuss and explore critical social, political, and economic issues, reveal underlying assumptions and understandings of influencers and their work, which I argue becomes part of informal governance of the creator economy, relying on social norms to hold influencers accountable. In this article, I am interested in how calling out undisclosed ads represents an intersection of these practices with legal rules about this content.

Regulating influencers' commercial content

When influencers engage in influencer marketing by receiving compensation, whether money, commissions, free goods, or services, from a third party in exchange for creating content, they produce commercial content (see also Stoldt et al., 2019). Irrespective of whether this is called branded content or sponsored posts, it constitutes a form of advertising. Unlike paid platform ads that are labelled by platforms as ads or promoted, influencer ads are self-disclosed, requiring influencers to separate their commercial content from organic content. This is part of platform governance (Annabell et al., 2024) and often a legal requirement under consumer and media law: consumers must be clearly informed about the existence of a commercial relationship between the influencer and the brand.

A strand of advertising and communication research aims to understand how disclosures contribute to this goal of transparency. Studies on how people perceive different types of disclosures and their effects on persuasion (Boerman, 2020; Evans et al., 2017; Pergelova & Hachey, 2023) offer mixed results about how effective disclosures are. This foregrounds the issue of advertising literacy and, importantly, suggests that meanings can be attached to disclosures, but it does not examine how people interpret them. There is evidence that disclosures may 'protect' users by activating recognition of the persuasive intent behind content, but we lack understanding of what disclosures mean to users when they encounter content on platforms. Insights into what disclosures mean for users as they encounter content on platforms.

Other work suggests that the focus on disclosure should shift toward the broader issue of influencer marketing ethics. Wellman et al. (2020) found that influencers use authenticity as a guiding ethical framework to shape their sponsored content, viewing their legal obligation to disclose as necessary only to avoid negative consequences. In a similar vein, Borchers and Enke (2022) highlighted that influencers see disclosures as unnecessary in their communication because of their focus on transparency and followers' expectations of truthfulness in all messages. These studies suggest that disclosure can be both conceptually anchored to authentic, transparent influencer practices and minimised as a legal requirement that is not essential when applying ethical principles in their content.

Although based on the US and German contexts, this perspective may help explain why influencers may not disclose commercial content. The European Commission (2024) found low disclosure rates through its sweep of 22 member states, supporting academic research. Within computer science, the detection of undisclosed ads is a machine-learning task in which models can be trained and developed (Bertaglia et al., 2023; Kim

et al., 2021; Zarei et al., 2020). This assumes features like brand tags and cues can be decoded to identify undisclosed commercial content. In part, this resonates with Hall's (1980) model: producers embed meaning within the content through the economic and technical infrastructure of production, while audiences decode content using personal and social resources in ways that may align with, oppose, or reinterpret the intended message. I argue that this can help us understand how some influencer content is interpreted as undisclosed ads, the meanings assigned to disclosure labels, and how perspectives on the creator economy, platform rules, and legal frameworks shape how influencers and audiences recognise undisclosed ads.

When it comes to the intersection of calling out and disclosure practices among influencers, Lee and Abidin (2024) examine how advertorials are linked to cancel culture. They trace the circulation of gossip across platforms and outlets after media reports revealed undisclosed commercial content from two YouTube influencers in Korea. Their analysis of user comments shows a weaponisation of calling out and cancelling where 'misogyny, fat-shaming, and insults' (p. 418) were justified as 'an act of social justice' (p. 419). Building on insights from this case, I explore how undisclosed ads are called out on TikTok, focusing on how the issue of disclosure is framed and connected to gendered views of influencers, as well as negotiated as governance through the 'successful' decoding of undisclosed ads and monitoring of commercial content by different actors.

Research design

To explore how undisclosed influencer ads are called out on TikTok, I identify and analyse narratives in TikTok videos and comments. I adopted a purposive sampling technique, using keyword searches, including hidden, undisclosed and non-disclosed influencer ads, sponsored and branded content, influencer marketing, and recommended content through TikTok's For You Page on a new TikTok account to curate a dataset of callout videos. This prioritised videos focused on disclosure and references to a different legal framework that were analytically rich in terms of video and comment content. Working with 14 videos from six influencers allows for in-depth analysis of the callouts and their comments.

I transcribed the audio and captured screenshots of specific scenes from each video (see Figure 1). The web-scraping browswer extension, Zeeschuimer (Peeters, 2022) was used to

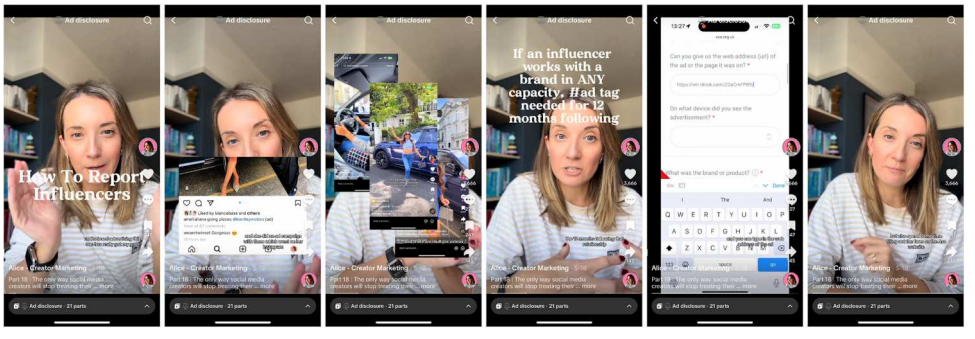


Figure 1. Screenshots from Alice's callout of Amelia Liana's undisclosed TikTok videos advertising Bentley.

collect comments and metadata from these videos (see also Caliandro et al., 2024). To preserve the interactional context, I classified them as standalone (comments with no replies), thread originators (comments with replies), or replies (comments in a thread). My analysis is based on a subset of the top 10 most liked comments, and if the comment was a thread originator, I included all the corresponding replies ($n = 1714$ comments). Consequently, the analysis focuses on discussion within highly liked comments, emphasising engagement, which is influenced by TikTok's comment recommendation algorithm.

I also sourced content from four influencers identified in callout videos as undisclosed ads, using their account names along with screenshots and recordings (see Figure 2 for an example). If comments from this content mentioned disclosure or advertising, I collected them using Zeeschuimer and curated a subset of only relevant comments. In cases where this was part of a reply thread, I included the entire thread for analysis. This resulted in a dataset of 211 comments from 10 videos.

I use discourse analysis to closely examine language use and how social meanings are constructed in videos and comments (Page et al., 2022). This is based on the understanding that narratives shared on social media are complex processes of sense-making embedded within discursive practices and environments. It is also inspired by Georgakopoulou (2017) 'small stories' heuristic by paying attention to the communicative 'how,'

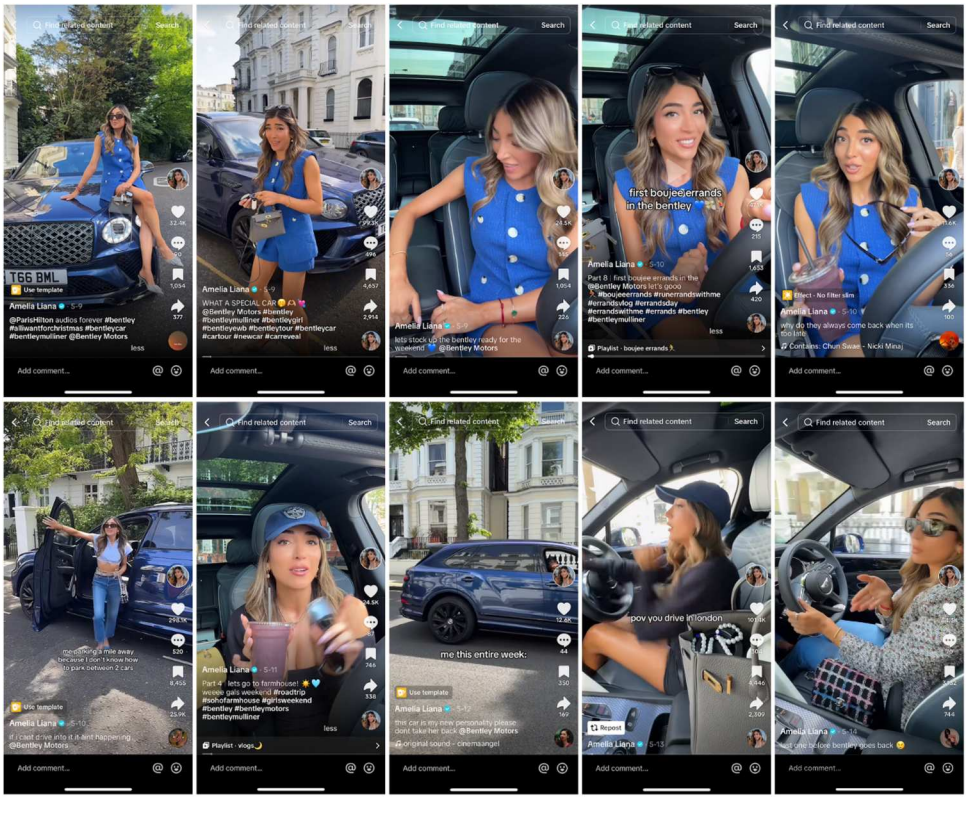


Figure 2. Screenshots from Amelia's TikTok videos featuring the Bentley, identified by Alice as undisclosed ads. The second, fifth and eighth screenshots are visible in Alice's video.

the interplay of affordances and storytelling practices, and the participants in the interaction. I examine the co-construction of calling out in videos and comments, focusing on how users elaborate on and diverge from issues of disclosure, advertising and governance. The visual elements are also brought into the analysis through interpretation of scene-by-scene timelines following Caliandro et al. (2024) templatability approach.

While the names of and direct quotes from influencers are used, I do not include usernames or text of comments. Unlike influencers whose pursuit of visibility is clear through their content (e.g., hashtagging practices, modes of address) and engagement with commenters (Abidin, 2020), the expectation of publicness for commenters remains unclear. Thus, I distinguish between public and private figures, following a context-sensitive approach to enacting methods *as* ethics (Markham et al., 2018).

Influencers as decoders and governors of commercial content

On TikTok, some influencers position themselves as governors within the creator economy who are protecting audiences by drawing attention to the presence of undisclosed ads on the platform. To do this, they create callout videos explaining why disclosure matters, identifying and criticising undisclosed or improperly disclosed commercial content shared by other influencers, who are portrayed as exemplifying and even representing poor industry practices.

Across the 14 callout videos, two modes of interpretation are present: undisclosed ads as illegal and misleading, and undisclosed ads as immoral and unethical. While these constructions co-occur, I separate them for analysis to clarify their differences.

Undisclosed ads illegal

The repeated claims by influencers that undisclosed ads are 'illegal' set up the seriousness of disclosure practices. By framing disclosure as a legal requirement and citing specific laws and authorities such as the UK's ASA, the US's Federal Trade Commission, and Canada's Competition Bureau, influencers lend legitimacy to these frameworks and align themselves with these agencies as trustworthy protectors. Consumer protection language is often employed; Alice (2024a, see Supplemental data) describes undisclosed ads as 'very misleading,' and Bee Better (2024a, see Supplemental data) states that consumer laws address 'fraudulent, deceptive marketing tactics that may influence their buying and purchasing decisions.' These legal standards are portrayed as the benchmark for best practices as influencers evaluate undisclosed ads against official rules, endorsing this governance system. It also helps influencers establish themselves as experts with legal knowledge within the creator industry, reinforcing their self-image as informal regulators who help oversee influencer activity.

Due to their positions in the industry, all influencers are assumed to be aware of laws that apply or, as Alice (2024a, see Supplemental data) puts it, 'what their responsibilities are in terms of disclosure.' The educational value of the callout is for the unknowing audience, constructed in opposition to the informed influencer who is intentionally evading their obligations, as Bee Better (2024a, see Supplemental data) makes clear: 'I'm speaking to the audience now, not the influencers, because they're already well aware of this.' Because of their informed status, undisclosed ads reflect the professionalism

and ethos of the influencer. Carelessness and, as Bee Better (2024b, see Supplemental data) quips, shamelessness, are associated with influencers who do not disclose, because this is understood as an active choice: 'And I won't name names, but Mikayla Nogueira is somebody that comes to mind as somebody that has consistently, repeatedly, shamelessly done this, allegedly.' Here, 'allegedly' is a way to hedge his claims while also being juxtaposed with the adverbs that intensify the callout and serve as a discursive reminder of how the issue of legality frames the issue.

The construction of influencers as knowingly noncompliant dovetails with that of the audience, who are presented as vulnerable and in need of protection. Bee Better (2024a, see Supplemental data) interpellates 'you guys as consumers' and refers to the 'average person watching' when explaining why disclosure is necessary. More overtly, Alice (2023b, see Supplemental data) states that the 'millions of people that use social media' cannot recognise influencer content as advertising. Therefore, she presents herself as educating audiences about the business models in the creator economy, where influencers 'do a lot of advertisements, that they are vehicles for selling things. They are called influencers because they influence.' Alice frames 'influence' within the realm of commercial decisions, implying an impact on purchasing behaviour and hinting at the importance of undisclosed ads. Although Alice is discerning and capable of recognising undisclosed ads, this commercial content is assumed to be hidden and invisible to others, making disclosure necessary.

The vulnerability of audiences becomes more pronounced based on their identity characteristics and relationships with influencers. Alice (2024b, see Supplemental data) speaks of 'teenagers' and 'people who really buy into the lives of influencers,' while Lacey (2024a, see Supplemental data) describes followers as 'gullible and they continue to support, follow, have a parasocial relationship with' and Bee Better (2024b, see Supplemental data) highlights a 'younger audience and, primarily female audience.' This partly involves using consumer protection language around vulnerability but also taps into gendered moral panics and perpetuates the debasement of imagined audience arguments put forward in media research. Influencer followers are, therefore, viewed as being exploited financially and naïve, unable to resist persuasive influencer advertising.

Yet, the audience is also encouraged to actively participate in the governance system. Alice (2024c, see Supplemental data) models how to report undisclosed ads to the ASA, using a screen recording of her reporting content by Amelia Liana. While she admits that 'no one has the time to report every undisclosed ad that we see; we would be here all day,' she legitimises reporting as a responsible action by audiences. Crucially, in this case, Alice constructs the audience as discerning, expecting them to recognise undisclosed ads and feel empowered through her legal expertise. Due to the high rates of undisclosed ads, which are presented as shared knowledge, instances that irritate viewers or 'really get your goat' should influence how they choose what to report. This shows how personal feelings about specific influencers bleed into discussions of disclosure as governance. But what is missing is a consideration of how this monitoring might be unevenly distributed among influencers, intersect with a gendered backlash, and potentially be weaponised (Meisner, 2023), raising questions about what responsible governance looks like for influencers engaged in calling out.

Undisclosed ads as immoral

Influencers also consider undisclosed ads as problematic beyond legality, emphasising that disclosure is an ethical issue and can be considered 'morally wrong' (Lacey, 2024b, see Supplemental data). When disclosures are viewed as reflecting both professional and personal identity, there is a slippage between discussing the issue of undisclosed ads and making a normative judgment about influencers. Alice (2024a, see Supplemental data), in analysing Chris Olsen's undisclosed ad within his cultivation of parasocial relationships, argues he is 'essentially lying,' which she says is 'an erosion of trust.' She considers it deceptive because of the lack of transparency about the content's nature (i.e., his trip to Australia was a paid promotion for Tourism Australia). Additionally, framing the situation as impulsive conceals the planning and organisation behind brand trips. Alice points to comments under his content, showing how some users felt guilty about not being able to afford such trips or travel spontaneously. Here, Alice links deception to harm, suggesting that such feelings might have been avoided if the content had been disclosed as an ad.

In decoding undisclosed ads as deceptive, some influencers refer to the underlying motivations behind this practice:

> They're influencers who will look you in the eye through this camera hole and will literally lie to your face about the fact that this product changed their life when it is, in fact, a brand deal in order to weaponise the audience that they have and manipulate you into moving tens of millions of dollars' worth of product. (Bee Better, 2024a, see Supplemental data)

> Can you imagine lying to 15.5 million people every single day and having absolutely no remorse about it? I guarantee your answer is probably no, because any honest person would feel very guilty about doing that. (Lacey, 2024a, see Supplemental data)

The influencer, imagined by Bee Better and hypothetical but described using explicit references to Mikayla by Lacey, is assumed to be driven by commercial interests and emerges as a manipulative, money-hungry figure. In the context of who is being called out, this construction reinforces stereotypes of deceitful, superficial, and insincere work, which are gender-coded (Duffy et al., 2022).

The understanding of the influencer is linked with the audience. Lacey separates the 'you' as the imagined 'honest person' from the influencer who lies 'with no remorse' or guilt. Bee Better, on the other hand, emphasises the gullible, passive audience discussed earlier, implying that 'you' are manipulated into buying what influencers promote. Robert (2023a) offers an alternative perspective on the relationship between disclosure, audiences, and ethical practices. In encouraging the beauty TikTok community to disclose ads, he proposes audiences 'will be fine with it. When it gets annoying is when you don't disclose it, cause that's pure dishonesty.' Dishonesty is only attributed to undisclosed ads, not to the creation of commercial content. This raises the issue of how people interact with ads, hinting at why influencers may not disclose ads: users scroll past when they recognise content as an ad (thanks to disclosure), which negatively impacts engagement metrics for the ad and thus, their market value. In the analysed callout videos, reasons for nondisclosure are limited to unethical, immoral, and deliberately non-compliant attitudes and actions of influencers.

Decoding undisclosed ads

Across the callout videos, influencers present visual and verbal evidence that specific influencers are not correctly disclosing content as advertisements. TikTok's Stitch feature, overlaid screenshots, or embedded screen recordings are used to show the audience 'proof' of undisclosed commercial content as the influencer explains how it should be decoded as an ad. For example, Bee Better (2024a, see Supplemental data) circles in red #Keihlspartner within the screenshot of Haley's TikTok video, narrating, 'you can see in the very tippy top right corner in microscopic lettering, literally the smallest text size that TikTok would physically allow somebody to do.' Like most callouts, Bee Better points to #partner as a clear sign of a commercial relationship, and aligns himself with regulatory authorities also concerned with where disclosures can be placed and acceptable terminology.

Alice draws upon additional resources to contextualise her identification of undisclosed ads. This includes showing content shared by the influencer previously on TikTok and other platforms – sometimes disclosed as advertising – to show why this specific instance also should have been disclosed. Regarding Emily's Ninja Creami content, Alice (2023a, see Supplemental data) points out Emily's repeated use of the brand name and her market value: 'There is no way that with one million followers, Emily Canham was not compensated to talk about that right then.' These clear assertions, therefore, identify content like Emily's as unquestionably undisclosed commercial content that needs to be called out.

Alongside influencers invoking professional expertise through their attention to detail, decoding content, and gathering evidence, governance is also portrayed as personal and emotional. Alice (2024a, see Supplemental data) describes recognising undisclosed ads as an embodied affective experience, recalling how her 'compliance spidey senses' felt 'tingly' when seeing Chris's Australian content. She feels 'totally vindicated' by news media reports affirming it was of a commercial nature, but it is unclear whom she feels vindicated against. This framing suggests petty drama (Geusens et al., 2023), blurring the lines between personal relationships and accountability practices. Similarly, in one of Emily's (2023a) callouts, the on-screen text states: 'When I'm in a bad mood, I go to the #bloompartner hashtag and report all the improperly disclosed ads,' overlaid with a screen recording of her reporting. Again, #partner is decoded as advertising and, therefore, is grounds for reporting, using a private governance mechanism rather than a national authority, as Alice (2024c, see Supplemental data) did. It is implied that this action positively affected Emily's 'bad mood,' alluding to a sense of justice and foregrounding agency, while also leaning into enforcement of regulations for personal reasons and governance as drama.

Across the callout videos, only women and queer men influencers have their disclosure practices scrutinised. Bee Better (2024a, see Supplemental data) uses Hayley's incorrect disclosure of her Kiehl's ad as the core example in his critique of influencers, only also naming Mikayla Nogueira, the '*queen* of not disclosing her partnerships and her brand affiliations,' akin to Alice's description of Grace as the '*queen* of illegal ad practices.' This highlights the gendered policing of influencers (Duffy et al., 2022).

The implications of calling out specific individuals as representative is acknowledged by Bee Better (2024a, see Supplemental data). He pre-empts the interpretation of calling

out as 'bullying' by positioning disclosures as part of the influencer's professional identity and as part of his role as governor, upholding accountability, rather than participant in gossip or drama culture. In his follow-up video, Bee Better (2024b, see Supplemental data) clarifies his intention was 'not to send hate,' nor does he see Hayley as the 'poster child for deceptive influencer marketing tactics.' However, public naming and shaming, as a form of peer regulation, can have serious consequences for the individual being called out, which Bee Better hints at. Additionally, he is hesitant to accept responsibility for how focusing on one of Hayley's videos may impact her, raising questions about what ethics should guide calling out practices, especially given the gendered nature of the industry.

Commenters support and contestation of disclosure as governance

In callout videos, influencers present calling out undisclosed ads as necessary because undisclosed ads are illegal, unethical, and immoral; influencers are knowingly non-compliant, deceptive, and driven by commercial interests, while audiences remain vulnerable, gullible, and discerning. Examining the ten most liked comments and their replies across these videos, I analyse how the value of disclosure is negotiated as a form of governance. While commenters support and expand on the narratives in callout videos, they also challenge the premise of the callout, question the influencer's neutrality, and discuss the named and shamed influencer moving beyond the issue of disclosure.

Discerning users

Some of the analysed comments show how TikTok users understand regulations that affect influencer content. Users referred to regulators and authorities, compared disclosure rules across different countries, and debated the correct form of disclosure based on legal guidelines. This indicates that viewing undisclosed content as illegal reflects an awareness of influencers' disclosure responsibilities. For example, comments about 'brand ambassador' and thanking sponsors as insufficient disclosure were points on terminology that were not discussed in the videos. Thus, the inability of audiences to decode undisclosed ads and their subsequent need for protection through public calling are subtly challenged.

Comments also served as a space for users to share their experiences reporting undisclosed ads to the ASA, FTC, and TikTok. Interestingly, this was mainly evident in callout videos that did not instruct people to do so. Some users reported blocking accounts, suggesting the aversion extends beyond the undisclosed ad of the influencer. These different reporting mechanisms indicate how users actively respond to undisclosed ads, demonstrating how governance systems for submitting feedback and complaints are proactively taken up.

Comments also discussed the role of advertising in the influencer industry and on TikTok. Some users highlighted the necessity of influencer marketing as a critical way for influencers to earn money. The TikTok algorithm was theorised to limit the visibility of disclosed ads, so some users intentionally interacted with disclosed ads as a form of support. Conversely, others stated they would scroll past content once they recognised it as an ad. In a thread on Bee Better's (2024a, see Supplemental data) video, phrases

decoded as common influencer language, especially in ad content, were discussed. These comments gesture towards a theory of nondisclosure: when users are alerted to the commercial nature of content, they disengage. Users expressed frustration over what they saw as an infiltration of ads on TikTok, both platform ads and influencer ads, and a culture of overpromotion by influencers, to the extent that some comments implied all influencer content was advertising. The visibility of disclosure, while protecting consumers, also, then, works against influencers by reminding users they are the audience commodity being sold to advertisers.

Disputing the value of calling out

Calling out undisclosed ads as a form of governance was also the subject of comments. Some users praised and thanked influencers for callout videos, seeing them as holding influencers accountable and sparking necessary conversations. Comments indicating surprise that the identified influencer content was an ad also alluded to the necessity of calling out such content. However, the absence of disclosure was not seen as manipulative. The narrative that undisclosed ads are harmful to audiences was only present when referring to gullible 'others' compared to the more discerning 'self.' This perception often reflected generational differences (e.g., Gen Z; Sephora kids), sometimes referencing the commenter's own children.

Other comments critiqued influencers for their callouts. Users expressed indifference toward disclosures, claiming the issue was not that serious, deep, or meaningful, and suggested that public criticism was not an act of governance. Rather, it was seen as an attempt to undermine successful influencers out of jealousy, as unnecessary moral policing, and to stir up drama. Sometimes, this involved recognising the benefit of callout videos for generating likes or indirectly promoting their businesses. In this way, users show how they are aware of the potential monetisation of callout culture and question the motives behind it because of how these influencers are involved in the industry.

Disclosure to hate pipeline

There was also substantial evidence that attention placed on called-out influencers because of their disclosure practices was redirected to criticising other aspects. This included the influencer's likeability, relatability, appearance, voice, and personality. For example, comments speculated about Mikayla's use of Ozempic shift to engage in body-shaming and misogyny, detached from the disclosure issue, much like the findings of Lee and Abidin (2024). Alongside negative remarks, comments also amplified the portrayal of influencers as deceptive, fake, lying, and untrustworthy, intensifying narratives from videos and invoking a gendered policing of authenticity (Duffy et al., 2022). The undisclosed ad is used as a synecdoche for the influencer's trustworthiness. This raises questions about the limits of governance through calling out undisclosed ads, given the blurred boundaries between viewing an influencer as an individual and a professional actor. Although influencers who initiate the callout in their videos do not express harmful or hateful feelings or beliefs, some users treat it as an opportunity to surface such views through their comments.

Audience ambivalence towards undisclosed ads

The mixed feelings about disclosure seen in comments on callout videos are also evident in comments on content identified as undisclosed ads. 24 videos had no comments concerning disclosure or advertising, while out of 2342 comments on 10 videos, 211 discussed disclosure and advertising issues. This shows ambivalence toward the issue, which is reflected in how it is expressed.

Firstly, 2 out of 478 comments on Mikayla's video featuring Tim McGraw, identified by Bee Better (2024b, see Supplemental data) as an undisclosed ad, anticipated and called out that this was commercial content. Both comments were standalone, received few likes, and had no replies.

Secondly, seven out of Amelia's 10 videos featuring the Bentley include comments that address the lack of disclosure. Crucially, these are not stand-alone comments but are nested within a thread. When a user asks a question or mentions the car, the number of Bentley videos, or Amelia's financial situation, another user identifies the car as a 'loan' or 'gift,' and that this renders the content an 'ad,' 'paid promotion,' or 'partnership.' Disclosure is viewed as providing essential context for understanding the content, as users help govern commercial content when they see others being misled. Calling out is therefore seen as a supportive action for the community.

Thirdly, the video with the most comments ($n = 142$) about disclosure and advertising is on Hayley's video advertising Kiehl's, reposted with the 'correct' disclosure after the callout. On the one hand, comments praised the repost as a sign of accountability, honesty, and a gracious response to the callout, portraying her as a role model for the industry. Several users mentioned their intention to buy the product and follow Hayley. Although less common, others challenged this support, suggesting she knowingly violated rules and disclosed for the wrong reasons. Additionally, comments referenced Bee Better's callout, contributing to a feedback loop where Bee Better drives engagement beyond his own content. Overall, these comments show a mostly positive outcome of the callout, despite Bee Better's (2024b, see Supplemental data) reflection implying she faced hate, which hints at some moderation of negative comments.

While videos contain declarative assertions that univocally establish the necessity of publicly calling out influencers as an act of good governance, the issue becomes more diluted when looking at the comments on the content itself. Undisclosed ads are rarely called out in comments, even though transparency is perhaps most needed here – the site where consumers may be most vulnerable to commercial messaging. Yet, while this might suggest low awareness, it does not account for comment moderation, other actions like reporting, or how audiences may decode commercial intent when disclosures are not present.

Discussion

Across jurisdictions, legal advertising, consumer and media law require such commercial content to be demarcated from so-called organic content to provide transparency to audiences (Goanta & Ranchordás, 2020), which is reinforced by platform rules similarly establishing disclosure as a crucial governance mechanism (Annabell et al., 2025). While the presence of undisclosed ads on feeds has been subject to regulatory concern and

scholarly attention in disciplinary contexts of assessing the effectiveness of disclosure for consumers (Boerman, 2020; Evans et al., 2017; Pergelova & Hachey, 2023) or computationally identifying undisclosed ads (Bertaglia et al., 2023; Kim et al., 2021; Zarei et al., 2020), I have addressed how undisclosed ads are interpreted and understood by influencers and audiences.

Influencers engaged in callouts view disclosures as a necessary legal duty, ethical acts of transparency, and a reflection of their professional identity. While some users, according to the analysed comments, reinforce this view, others assume a commercial intent behind content production regardless of disclosure. Within the distribution of governance in the creator economy, there is thus a convergence among some influencers and audiences with regulators that disclosure *is* the way to govern commercial content with attempts to enforce rules, thereby conferring legitimacy on this formal legal framework. As the European Union drafts the Digital Fairness Act, this study indicates disclosures do matter. But, knowing when to disclose is treated largely as unproblematic, smoothing out challenges about how to interpret and apply existing legal frameworks, which regulators could help to rectify. The straightforward argument that influencers are knowingly uncompliant is only nuanced in user comments rather than in callout videos, demonstrating how the narrativisation of a legal obligation becomes tied to moral and ethical assessment, and is shaped by calling out practices, which makes it distinct from monitoring of compliance. Overall, the absence of disclosure is assumed to be deliberate, aimed at furthering the influencer's commercial goals and hidden from certain groups, requiring media literacy to decode its commercial nature effectively. This construction relies on the audience being presented as vulnerable and gullible because of their age, gender, and parasocial relationship, while also being expected to actively participate in regulating commercial content by reporting. The tension between these two positions remains resolved within callout content and indicates a need for literacies around commercial content.

Alongside addressing how a legal framework is interpreted in the creator economy (Hallinan et al., 2024; Kaye & Gray, 2021), I have also contributed to research on calling out practices (Geusens et al., 2023; Lawson, 2021; Lee & Abidin, 2024; Lewis & Christin, 2022; Nakamura, 2015), which reconfigures issues of accountability as legal knowledge becomes a source of content and is connected to the commercial position of influencers. Conceptually, I have proposed that calling out practices reveals how influencers and audiences position themselves as governors of the creator economy. For these individuals, the identification and critique of undisclosed ads demonstrate an endorsement of governance through disclosure, which informs their actions of calling out and reporting to platforms or regulators as facilitating the enforcement of rules deemed necessary and essential. Attending to both influencers and users by tracing narratives and interpretations across callout videos, their comments, and comments on content believed to be non-compliant allows the variety and intensity of callout practices among different actors to be grappled with. This, I propose, furthers methodological approaches of calling out practices, which previously focused either on influencers or audiences.

My findings also speak to the limits of social media callouts as a form of accountability due to engagement and drama logics, which have implications beyond this case study. As the analysis has demonstrated, influencers leverage their legal knowledge by monitoring influencer activity, decoding their undisclosed commercial content,

and publicly calling out undisclosed ads in the name of governance, which is packaged as engaging and even rage-baiting content. Therefore, accountability is firmly embedded in visibility strategies and monetisation practices: influencers are promoting themselves as governors of the creator economy, commenters are fuelling drama, and both are deciding what is worth attention. These dynamics influence the format and tone of callout videos and create incentives for spreading regulatory discussions. Engagement with callout content benefits the influencer, and depending on their participation in the TikTok creator fund, may translate into income. Critically, callout content may dovetail with additional business activities such as selling products or services such as influencer coaching about legal obligations. This means that calling out as a 'discursive accountability practice' (Clark, 2020, p. 89) is mediated by callout as content genre and source of drama (Geusens et al., 2023; Lewis & Christin, 2022) and as such, research on calling out must be analytically sensitive towards identifying how accountability is distributed and for what ends.

The limits of what calling out are also evident in the drift from the issue of disclosure in callout content and comments. Because of its relationship to advertising and income, calling out undisclosed ads by specific influencers becomes a way to dismiss influencer labour and to justify attacking and insulting influencers, separate from the issue of disclosure. These attacks tend to be gender-coded and continue the pattern of gendered moral policing of influencers (Duffy et al., 2022; Geusens et al., 2023). Against the backdrop of feminised digital labour, the so-called unethical and immoral practice of not disclosing, coupled with the assumed commercial motivations of influencers, allows (non)compliance to be another stage on which work is minimised. The gendered stereotype of 'rich, vain, young women' (Abidin, 2016) takes on additional counters of lack of responsibility and professionalism as represented through their poor governance. This also applies to influencers who share callout content. Lacey (2024b, see Supplemental data) mentioned in her follow-up video that she received 'hateful comments' and was 'attack[ed] the way that I look and attack[ed] me because they're upset that I'm holding an influencer that they have a parasocial relationship with accountable for their actions.' Both videos had comments disabled when the data were collected, speaking to the shift in focus from disclosure to identity, which impacts her ongoing presence on the platform. Thus, accountability is also seen as extending to audiences, as some influencers also implore people to reflect on their responses to callouts, alluding to the boundaries between calling out harmful behaviour and causing harm.

The role that TikTok plays in governing and benefiting from the creator economy, including undisclosed ads, calling out practices and harmful responses, is largely overlooked in calling out practices. Yet, the platform is deeply implicated, and I argue this research has implications for areas in which they should assume greater responsibility in the governance landscape. This could take the form of proactive identification of undisclosed ads hosted on their platform and influencers could be nudged to check their disclosure of content flagged as potentially content. Platforms could debunk the assumption that disclosure is algorithmically punished through the provision of data, recognising how this theory disincentivises disclosure. In addition, platforms could reflect on how their algorithmic systems might reward the amplification of drama or personal attacking of influencers in the surfacing of content and comments.

Conclusion

This article has examined how disclosure, as a form of governance, is the subject of calling out on TikTok. By analysing callout videos, their comments, and comments on the alleged undisclosed ads, the study has addressed interpretations of disclosure as (1) meaningful, aligning with the influencer's commercial goals, and leaving certain groups vulnerable because they are presumed to be unable to decode its commercial nature; and (2) unnecessary due to ambivalence toward governance through disclosure. I have argued there is a strategic use of regulation by actors who position themselves as governors of influencer culture.

This study is limited, however, by its focus on a small number of TikTok videos calling out disclosure of influencers within beauty and lifestyle content. The visibility of comments used in this analysis is also shaped by moderation processes of TikTok and influencers. As such, the understanding of what disclosure means and how it is made to matter emerges from the particularities of TikTok cultures and governance regimes as well as their representation within comment and content rather than being reflective of personal beliefs. Nevertheless, their articulation on TikTok has implications for the ongoing negotiation of governance because of the engagement with the topic in public spaces.

Future studies could explore how calling out of disclosure across different platforms and content niches, allowing for comparative reflections, particularly in relation to gender. Conducting interviews and focus groups with influencers and audiences to examine understanding of regulation in the creator economy more broadly, as well as the specific mechanisms of governance through disclosure and calling-out practices, would offer valuable qualitative insights into the intersection of regulation, influencer practices, and consumer harms. Additionally, how *good* governance is distributed across the ecosystem requires further theorisation and empirical research to inform regulatory discussions, particularly as regulators focus on influencer marketing, as indicated by the European Union's Digital Fairness Act.

Acknowledgements

Special thank you to Dr Brooke Erin Duffy and the Creators & Platform Labor Research Group at Cornell University for their feedback on an early version of this paper.

Author contributions

CRediT: **Taylor Annabell:** Conceptualization, Data curation, Methodology, Writing – original draft.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Funding

This work is supported by ERC Starting Grant HUMANads under ERC-2021-StG No 101041824.

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Data availability statement

Data is available in the appendices.

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